NeuralSpark

Understanding the Research Paper in Plain English

The Core Ideas, Tech Stack, and Why It Matters

Arjun Oundhkar, Asmit Bishnoi, Aniket, and Vedant Shah

Department of AI & Data Science

Parul Institute of Engineering and Technology, Parul University, Vadodara, India

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What is this document?

This is a companion guide to the NeuralSpark research paper. It explains every major concept, technical decision, and result from the paper in simple, everyday language — no PhD required. If you've read the paper and felt lost in the jargon, this is for you.

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1 The Big Picture: What Problem Does NeuralSpark Solve?

Imagine you're a college professor teaching a Computer Science class with 500 students. Every week, you assign an open-ended question like *"Explain how Binary Search works and state its time complexity."*

Now you have 500 handwritten or typed answers to read, understand, compare against a scoring rubric, assign partial marks, and write feedback for. At 2 minutes per answer, that's **over 16 hours of non-stop grading** — just for one question, one week.

This is the **assessment scalability crisis**. Teachers are drowning in grading work, students wait days for feedback, and the whole process is exhausting and error-prone.

On top of that, students today use **five different platforms** for one course:

- YouTube or Coursera for video lectures
- Stack Overflow for asking coding questions
- Google Forms or Gradescope for submitting assignments
- WhatsApp groups for discussing with classmates
- Separate apps for previous year exam papers

NeuralSpark solves all of this in one place. It's a single website that combines:

1. **Video Lectures** — organized by subject and chapter order
2. **A Community Q&A Forum** — like Stack Overflow, but built into the learning platform
3. **Previous Year Question (PYQ) Archives** — searchable by year and subject
4. **AI-Powered Grading** — an AI that reads your answer, compares it to a rubric, and gives you a score and feedback *instantly*
5. **A Products & Services Marketplace** — for mock tests, books, and mentorship

2 The Star Feature: How Does the AI Grader Work?

The AI grading engine is the most innovative part of NeuralSpark. It works in **two modes** — think of them as a "premium" mode and a "free" mode.

2.1 Mode 1: The Cloud Grader (The "Premium Brain")

This mode sends your answer to a powerful AI called **Llama-4-Scout-17B** running on Groq's cloud servers. This AI has 17 *billion* parameters (think of parameters as the "brain cells" of the AI — more means smarter).

What makes it special:

- It can read **typed text**, **PDF documents**, *and* **photos of handwritten answers** simultaneously.
- It understands the **rubric** (the scoring rules) and compares your answer against each criterion.
- It gives you a **score AND written feedback** explaining exactly what you got right and wrong.
- It's incredibly accurate: **91.3% of the time**, its score is within 1 point of what a human teacher would give.

The trade-off: It requires an internet connection and costs a tiny amount per request (fractions of a cent).

2.2 Mode 2: The Local Grader (The "Free Offline Brain")

This mode uses a **smaller AI model called RoBERTa** that runs *directly on the server's CPU* — no internet needed, no cloud, no API fees.

How we built it:

1. We took a pre-trained RoBERTa model (a well-known AI model for understanding text).
2. We created a **custom training dataset** of computer science questions, rubrics, and student answers at different quality levels (perfect answers, partial answers, wrong answers).
3. We "fine-tuned" (re-trained) the model specifically to grade CS answers.
4. The result is a 328 MB file that lives on the server and grades answers in **under 200 milliseconds** — faster than blinking.

The trade-off: It's less accurate (84.7%) and gives only a numeric score, not written feedback.

2.3 Why Two Modes? The Best of Both Worlds

	Cloud Grader	**Local Grader**
Accuracy	91.3%	84.7%
Speed	2 seconds	0.2 seconds
Written Feedback	Yes	No
Reads Images	Yes	No
Needs Internet	Yes	No
Cost	Small fee	Free
Privacy	Data leaves server	100% private

Institutions can choose based on their priorities: use the cloud grader for exams where quality matters most, or the local grader for practice assignments where speed and cost matter more.

3 The Tech Stack: How Is It Built?

NeuralSpark is built as a **decoupled full-stack application**, which means the frontend (what you see) and the backend (the brains) are completely separate programs that talk to each other over the internet using a standard protocol called REST.

3.1 The Backend ("The Engine Room")

- **Django 6** — A Python web framework that handles all the server-side logic. Think of it as the operating system of the website.
- **Django Ninja** — A speed-optimized layer on top of Django that creates the API endpoints (the "doors" that the frontend knocks on to get data).
- **Pydantic** — A validation library that checks every piece of incoming data against strict rules. If someone sends a question without a title, Pydantic rejects it before it ever touches the database.
- **SQLite / PostgreSQL** — The database. SQLite for local development (a simple file), PostgreSQL for production (a full database server).
- **Groq SDK** — The connection to the cloud AI for grading.
- **HuggingFace Transformers** — The library that loads and runs the local RoBERTa model.

3.2 The Frontend ("The Showroom")

- **Next.js 16** — A React-based framework that renders the website. It can generate pages on the server (for speed) or in the browser (for interactivity).
- **React 19** — The UI library that builds all the interactive components.
- **Tailwind CSS 4** — A styling system where you design directly in the HTML using utility classes instead of writing separate CSS files.
- **Framer Motion** — An animation library that makes everything feel alive. The navbar slides down with a spring animation, cards fade in one by one, and buttons have hover effects.
- **Lucide React** — Beautiful, consistent icons throughout the interface.

3.3 The Deployment ("Where Does It Live?")

- **Frontend on Vercel** — Vercel is built by the same team that created Next.js. It deploys the frontend to a global CDN (Content Delivery Network), meaning the website loads fast whether you're in India, the US, or Europe.
- **Backend on Render.com** — The Django server runs on Render with a Gunicorn process manager. It connects to a PostgreSQL database in production.

4 The Community Forum: A Stack Overflow for Students

The forum is where students help each other. Here's how it works:

1. **Ask a question**: Any student can post a question with a title, body text, optional video link, and tags (like "Data Structures" or "SQL").
2. **Get answers**: Other students write answers. Answers start as **unapproved** (hidden) until a moderator reviews them — this prevents spam.
3. **Vote**: Students upvote helpful answers and downvote unhelpful ones. The best answers rise to the top automatically.
4. **Earn reputation**: When your answers get upvoted, your reputation score increases, creating a gamified incentive to contribute quality content.

5. **Comment**: Both questions and answers support threaded comments for follow-up discussions.

Every time someone views a question, the **view counter increases automatically**, providing real-time popularity metrics.

5 The Database: How Is All This Data Organized?

The platform stores data in 10 interconnected database tables:

Table	What It Stores
User	Student accounts with username, bio, and reputation score
Category	Subject areas (Data Structures, SQL, OS, etc.)
Tag	Topic labels that can be attached to questions
Lecture	Video lectures with title, URL, and chapter ordering
PYQ	Previous year exam questions organized by year
Question	Community forum posts with view counts and vote counts
Answer	Responses to questions, with approval status and votes
Comment	Discussion threads on questions or answers
Product	Marketplace items (mock tests, books) with prices
Service / Inquiry	Premium services and contact form submissions

All of these tables are connected through **foreign keys** (links between tables). For example, every Answer is linked to a Question, and every Question is linked to a User (the author).

6 The Dark Mode: A Small Feature with Big Impact

NeuralSpark supports both light and dark themes. When you toggle the theme:

1. The system saves your preference in `localStorage` (your browser's memory).

2. Next time you visit, it automatically applies your saved preference.

3. If you've never chosen, it detects your operating system's setting (e.g., if your Windows or Mac is in dark mode, the website follows).

This might sound trivial, but studies show that **dark mode reduces eye strain by up to 60%** during extended study sessions and improves battery life on OLED screens.

7 The Results: Does It Actually Work?

7.1 AI Grading Accuracy

We tested both AI graders against human expert graders on 100 computer science questions:

	Cloud AI	**Local AI**
Scores within ± 1 of human	91.3%	84.7%
Average error	0.42 points	0.89 points
Response time	2.1 seconds	0.175 seconds

For context, **two human graders agreed with each other 94% of the time**. The cloud AI (91.3%) is remarkably close to human-level performance.

7.2 What Makes the Cloud Grader Better?

The biggest advantage is **multimodal processing**. When we tested grading with just text, accuracy was 88.5%. When we added PDF support, it rose to 90.2%. When we added image support (photos of handwritten answers), it reached 91.3%. Each input type adds context that helps the AI grade more accurately.

7.3 Platform Speed

All regular operations (loading questions, posting answers, browsing lectures) complete in **under 100 milliseconds**. The AI grading takes 2 seconds on cloud and 0.2 seconds locally. The only slow moment is the very first time someone uses the local grader — the model takes about 9 seconds to load into memory. After that, it's instant.

8 Security: Is Student Data Safe?

- **CORS Protection**: Only the official NeuralSpark frontend can access the API. Random websites cannot steal data.
- **No Hardcoded Secrets**: API keys are stored in environment variables, never in the source code.
- **Input Validation**: Every piece of data is checked by Pydantic before being processed. You can't inject malicious code through the API.
- **SQL Injection Prevention**: Django's ORM uses parameterized queries, making SQL injection attacks impossible.
- **Content Moderation**: All answers are hidden until approved, preventing spam and offensive content from appearing publicly.
- **Local Grading Privacy**: When using the offline RoBERTa grader, student answers never leave the server. Zero data is transmitted to any external service.

9 What's Coming Next? (Future Work)

1. **Real-Time Tutoring**: Live peer-to-peer tutoring sessions using WebSockets, so students can get instant help.
2. **Better Local Grading**: Training larger models that can give written feedback (not just a score) while still running offline.
3. **Mobile App**: A React Native app that connects to the same backend, so students can learn on their phones.
4. **Multilingual Support**: Expanding the AI grader to handle non-English answers (Hindi, Gujarati, etc.).
5. **Proper Authentication**: Replacing the test user system with proper login using JWT tokens or OAuth2 (Google/GitHub login).

10 The Bottom Line

NeuralSpark is a **one-stop educational platform** that solves three real problems:

1. **Grading at scale**: AI grades answers in seconds instead of hours, with two modes (cloud for accuracy, local for privacy).

2. **Fragmented learning**: Lectures, Q&A, PYQs, marketplace, and grading all live in one place.

3. **Boring interfaces**: Premium animations, dark mode, and responsive design keep students engaged.

It's built with a modern, production-grade tech stack (Django + Next.js), deployed on real cloud infrastructure (Vercel + Render), and backed by actual AI models (Llama-4-Scout for cloud, fine-tuned RoBERTa for local).

In one sentence:

NeuralSpark is what happens when you combine Stack Overflow, Coursera, Gradescope, and ChatGPT into a single, beautiful, open-source platform that works even without the internet.